

THE EVIDENCE AND ITS BURDEN OF PROOF

September 23, 1980, was to become more than just a typically busy day for me in UFO matters. According to my UFOLOG, I note that I had communications by phone and mail with Joe Brill, Michael Dougan, Bob Gribble, Diane Saghe, and a journalist in Japan. And, there was an envelope with an APO San Francisco return address.

Of interest, of course, was Gribble's call concerning a new source, a trucker who reported that he had transported something secret for the military from Aztec, N. Mex., in the late 1940's, and a response to a letter I had sent to Saghe seeking information from a source she knew who had seen a captured saucer at a Texas airbase. But, standing out above all else was the letter, APO San Francisco, dated September 16, 1980. It was typed in proper military format on stationery with official letterhead. (See Figure 1. Note that I have deleted the Security Police Squadron number. The name of the sender has been changed to "Jeffrey Morse" in this report.)

Needless to say, I was stunned by the sergeant's bold disclosure of a military incident of fatal consequences at McGuire AFB, N.J. My first reaction was that it was a hoax, perhaps designed, if it were published, to embarrass or discredit my probes into UFO crash/retrievals. Still fresh in mind was another episode in 1980 involving questionable photographs received from a source under clandestine arrangements requiring my travel to another State. In this case, although my initial role was to have the photographs studied and authenticated, I made the mistake of announcing their acquisition at the 1980 MUFON symposium in Houston. Thanks to a swift and well-orchestrated smear campaign, researchers, by and large, became confused and questioned both the photographs and my credibility. A hoax? A stratagem to set me up? Probably, but a lesson was learned. (Note 1)

During this fragile period, being suspicious of any stranger with information to offer, I read Morse's letter over and over, and in between the lines, looking for anything detectably wrong. But, I could find nothing wrong. The letterhead was real, the military format was correct, the writer told his story as fact without emotional embellishment. Maybe, I reasoned, it was the sobriety of the official letterhead that made the story itself seem out of place with the real world. Like so many other stories of UFO close encounters it sounded like borderline fantasy, and some also involved the military, such as the British Rendlesham Forest Case. (Note 2)

Time will tell, I assured myself. Soon, Sgt. Morse would return home and if he had something of substance to back his claims it would be the breakthrough. I was determined to see this one case through disregarding time, energy, and cost. Proving it however, would be a monumental burden.

To better understand the incident and its ramifications, some of which later followed my source into civilian life, I believe it is essential to report verbatim most of my early exchanges of communications with him. This covers a span of time from

Morse's initial letter in 1980 into a period of apparent mail interference, then through his long interval of silence into his re-emergence in 1983.

As advised in Morse's overseas letter, my reply of September 27, 1980, was mailed to his home address. In the main, it was a message to establish a rapport of trust between us, one in which he could feel comfortable in sharing the burden of his experience, and to allay any anxieties he may have had about my research background. My questions were few and simple. One, for instance, asked for more descriptive detail of the recovered body; another asked how the body was removed from the scene and by whom and still another, if he could reveal any names of the personnel assigned to the area. I ended my letter with this thought: "Hope to hear from you soon and will follow your mailing instructions. Your letter will remain confidential at this time and, of course, your name not be used in any way."

Sgt. Morse, who was to be discharged and back home in November 1980, did not acknowledge my letter. Considering the time lapse as critical, I sent another letter November 18, 1980, quoted in part, "...Hope by now you're out of the service as you indicated in your letter from APO address...On September 27, I sent you a letter concerning my research endeavors which I trust you received at your home address. The incident you describe is, indeed, of interest to me and I hope you may find time soon to reach me by letter or phone, or, perhaps, to meet me at your convenience. You are certainly welcome to visit my home...I tried reaching you by phone last week, but your number is unlisted..."

In a letter dated November 27, 1980, from his home address, Morse answered as follows: "Sorry to have had such a delay in my response to you. I'm sorry to say I did not receive your letter of 27 September 1980. I haven't received any mail since August 1980. I don't know why. I am now out of the service and am home. I am prepared to answer your questions. I believe, however, I told you everything I know, but I'm not sure it was much to go on. But, I hope it leads you to someone who knows more about it. I'm sorry I can't recall too many names. The desk sergeant that night was Sgt. C (last name only) and he would know much more as fact. That's all I know of his name, however, I do remember that he was rather dedicated and may still be in the USAF. Well, I would like your next response ASAP and will try to give you my phone number by then."

On December 4, 1980, I sent Morse the following memorandum: "Your letter of November 27 arrived yesterday. I was surprised to learn that my letter of September 27 did not reach you. Fortunately, I kept a Xeroxed copy which I have duplicated and enclosed for your consideration. Hope you can send me your phone number. Enclosed is a gratis copy of my recently published Status Report II, which shows the scope of my research."

Again, Morse, for unknown reasons did not answer. Considering his expressed interest in my research and even allowing for other personal diversions, I thought that 2 ½ months were enough time for him to respond. On February 16, 1981, I wrote again,

expressing my concern and asked for a prompt reply as evidence of his sincerity. No answer.

Had it not been for Morse's brief letter of November 27 in which he asked for me to respond "ASAP" I would have dismissed his disclosure of the incident as questionable. Something was amiss. Or was the mail sent to this home being lost through negligence, a long shot, or lifted at his post office by directive to the Postmaster from one of the intelligence agencies? Whatever the method used to silence Jeffrey Morse, I reasoned, it was effective. All communications ceased and, like so many other informants in 1980, Morse became a phantom.

By March 1981, while preparing the text for Status Report III, I had decided it was time to take inventory; time for appraisal of the material on hand and of myself still in the midst of a heated controversy among researchers over the pros and cons of UFO crashes and retrievals. I needed outside thinking, and assessment of cases, a new perspective. To this end, I invited to my home two trustworthy friends who supported and contributed to my endeavors: Dr. Peter Rank, Chief of Radiology at the Methodist Hospital in Madison, Wis, and, Richard Hall, former Assistant Director of NICAP and then Editor of the MUFON UFO Journal. (Note 3) During our long, weekend chats, evaluating every case I planned to publish, we agreed that the Ft. Dix-McGuire encounter was among the foremost as to potential value, providing we could establish the genuineness of Morse. On this premise, I gave Hall his name and address, hopeful that new blood might stimulate his response.

On April 10, 1982, Hall sent Morse a certified letter offering, on my behalf, to meet him anywhere, anytime, to discuss the incident and provide my professional services and funds if needed. Curiously, the certified letter was received and signed for by Morse, April 12, but the silence continued. It continued for 17 months! Then, on September 27, 1983, Hall received an urgent letter from Morse, quoted as follows:

"I am writing you in regards to your letter, 10 April 1982. I'm sorry that it has taken so long to answer your letter. I had to be sure about you and your organization. My mail has not been monitored for some time now, however, I must not express my information in the letter form. I have been warned, threatened and I have personally been interrogated as recently as February 1983, in reference to the subject I discussed with Len Stringfield. I also have further information...which I know will interest you...I have the opportunity now to travel to D.C. area. So if you wish to contact me again, you should still have my address. Hope to hear from you soon. If after 2 weeks I have not heard from you, I will no longer acknowledge my participation with your group, nor will I answer any mail."

When Hall phoned the news to me I advised that he follow up quickly by letter and arrange for a meeting. Unfortunately, because of personal circumstances, Hall's reply, October 10, 1983, was sent a couple of days later than the deadline set by Morse.

Again, silence. On November 30, 1983, I wrote Morse the following letter, quoted in part:

"...I held off writing until today, hoping that a little breathing time would give you the motivation to write. It is difficult to believe that the mail I sent you in 1980 and 1981 failed to reach you, or, if you had received my letters that you were unable to reach me in some manner. Obviously, there was interference both ways...I felt hopeful that Hall's letter could open a new door of communications or, better still, a personal meeting with him. Now that several weeks have passed, I feel, again, concerned about your safety...Assuming you are still a 'free' person, I suggest you simply call me, reversing the charges...Jeff, please respond in some way, if only to acknowledge you received this letter."

Morse surfaced by phone on December 6, 1983, and I heard his voice for the first time. He called me at dinnertime, identifying himself by first name only. He said he felt safe now as enough time had passed since an official visitor warned him about his oath of secrecy. Talking cautiously for about 15 minutes, we covered the basics of many issues. Among his highpoints, however, were the disclosures that two days after the incident he and others on duty at the scene were summoned to Wright-Patterson AFB for interrogation, and that each was transferred promptly to a separate base overseas. His assignment was to a new Security Police Squadron in Okinawa. "Others," he said, "went to the Philippines, Germany, and Korea." Finally, he promised to answer my questions I had by letter and he gave me his phone number.

Morse's phone call opened the gates. I followed up the next day with a four-page letter in which I reiterated questions asked in 1980. Also, excerpted from my letter: "Your testimony is important. Of course, I'll need back-up witnesses such as Dick Hall so that credibility is established...Enclosed is a copy of Status Report III. Your report, Case A3 in on page 9 with my comments about our correspondence problems. At one point I wondered if you really existed or if your letter was a hoax. So, you can imagine my relief when I heard your voice."

Morse replied promptly, his letter post-marked December 14, 1983, included a map he sketched of the scene of action and a rough drawing of the body. (Answers, to some of my key questions appear later in the text of this paper wherever the subject is appropriate.) Additional information came by phone, December 13, 1983. In this exchange, I got the names and ranks of the officers who were his interrogators at Wright-Patterson. These, he said, were obtained from a source still in the Air Force he preferred not to identify.

With the Ft. Dix-McGuire case going from Square One to Square Two, my dialogue with Morse was now on a constant but cautious track, always mindful of surveillance.

The next event came as a surprise by certified mail postmarked December 23, 1983. On the flap of the envelope it said "Merry Christmas. I hope you like it." Inside,

was a Xeroxed copy of the Incident/Complaint Report (Form 1569) that Morse had hinted, by phone, he might be able to procure as important back-up. The Report was brief, but essentially contained the same story told by Morse. Prepared by Desk Sgt. WC and signed by 1st Lt. WS, it was channeled to Col. Landon, Commanding Officer of McGuire AFB; Brig. Gen. Brown, Hdq., 21st Air Force (at McGuire AFB); and the Air Force Office of Special Investigations (AFOSI). It contained the names of the security policemen involved, including Morse, and the name of the MP assigned to Ft. Dix whom Morse later identified as the person having shot the alien intruder. (See Figure 2, Incident/Complaint Report.) However, as agreed in our ensuing talks, I have deleted the names of the persons in the document. Also to protect the persons named, as he later confirmed when questioned, Morse had opaqued out the social security numbers opposite each name in the report. "These numbers are private," he said.

The document is avowedly not proof. For it to be established as bona fide would, in turn, require additional irretrievable reports, memoranda, tapes, ad infinitum. In this regard, however, Morse said on several occasions that he had attempted to obtain a later Form 1569 Report mentioned by the desk sergeant, but was unsuccessful. Nevertheless, the Incident/Complaint Report, as it stands, is a strong link of evidence not easily dismissed, even if denied officially or by any of its named personnel who might be coerced to so do. (Note 4)

The genesis for Case A-3 as it is designated in Status Report III is a taped rebroadcast over the Armed Forces Far Eastern Radio Network of an interview conducted by Charlie Tuna of KATZ, Los Angeles, July 28, 1980. I remember the interview well, concerning my UFO crash/retrieval probes at which time I was promoting Status Report II, published by MUFON. At the close of the interview, I gave my home address for listeners who might contribute information. By chance, Morse, with his new Security Police Squadron in Okinawa, heard it as did others in the U.S. Armed Forces in the Far East. As confirmation of this, I have a letter of inquiry from a serviceman, D. N. Cook, stationed in Korea who mentioned the broadcast. (Letter on file.)

To establish how it all began, I believe, is important for it diminishes the chance that Morse may have acted in collusion with a Stateside hoaxer. Also, to verify that he was stationed in Okinawa, I asked questions about the island's terrain and its little-known offshore island, Ie Shima. His answers were right on target as I knew these islands well, having been there myself with the 5th Air Force in World War II.

For the incident itself at McGuire AFB we have only Morse's word and his word only that it happened the way he described it based on his recall of his own experience and observations. Other than the Incident/Complaint Report which produced names, no other person has responded to Morse's request for back-up testimony. One letter he addressed to another member of his unit on patrol went unanswered; still another refused to surface to his request fearing for his career in the services. "No way," was the response.

Additional details about the affair came bit by bit based on specific questions by phone and letter during 1984, which are broken down for simplicity into categories as follow:

1. The Humanoid Factor. At varying times during his patrol duty, Morse was within 40 to 70 feet from the prostrate body on the abandoned runway #5. Never close enough to observe details such as facial features, or its hands and feet, he did recall that, under the glare of truck headlights, the skin of the unclad, hairless body was wet, shiny, and snake-like. As reported in his initial letter, the entity was about 4 feet in height with large head, slender torso, thin arms and legs, and overall, of grayish-brown coloration. Unquestionably not human, it was however of humanoid stature, fitting the anatomical description so often heard from military sources who have made claim to having seen entities at crash sites and as defined, coincidentally, by a medical source who allegedly performed an autopsy on a specimen in the early 1950's. (Note 5) (Also, see Figure 3, drawing by Morse.)

Always pressing for more detail, I once proffered the notion that the McGuire corpse could have been that of a wild animal, a deer perhaps or an escaped ape from a military experimentation lab, or a zoo. To this Morse replied, "No zoo nearby. We did have a problem with deer on the runway, but no one ever made such a big fuss over a deer."

The only other animal anomaly that Morse attributed to the presence of the body was the strong smell of ammonia in the cold night air, and, I note here that the same odor also prevailed at the alleged crash site in Case A-2 of Status Report III.

2. UFO Reports. Morse, who never sighted a UFO before or after the incident, was among many on duty who witnessed the bluish-green lights flying high and in tight formation over the adjoining Ft. Dix-McGuire bases. And, in the Incident/Complaint Report is the confirmation of their flight by the radar operator, A/IC R, on duty at the airbase control tower. Also, he had learned from the state trooper and later from his desk sergeant, WC, that one of the UFOs had come in at low level over the Ft. Dix MP's patrol car causing temporary failure of his radio transmission. (See Figure 4 and Figure 5. Drawings of UFO flight formation and map of Ft. Dix-McGuire showing sites of shooting and location of body, based on sketches by Morse.)

Although he never was able to see or talk with the Ft. Dix MP, JS, Morse did seek confirmation after his military service from the New Jersey State Police for their part in the incident, but he got nowhere, claiming they would not cooperate. Also, attempts to locate the state trooper he met at Gate #5 were futile. In this runaround, I recall Case A-8 in Status Report III where the police personnel involved in the 1966 Hillsdale-Dexter, Michigan, encounter were immediately transferred to new posts in the county, and that all records on their blotter regarding the incident were removed.